



The 12-acre Waghoba Eco Lodge, set amidst wildflowers, native trees and picturesque farmland (top); a safari inside Tadoba. With 100-odd tigers in the reserve, sightings of this magnificent, but shy, big cat are a good bet, if one's luck holds

WHERE THE WILD THINGS ARE

Even if tigers prove elusive in the Tadoba reserve, the newly opened Waghoba Eco Lodge quickly transforms disappointment into delight

By Ishani Nandi

"They were here, just a few minutes ago," Laxman, our forest guide, exclaims, pointing towards a wet smudge on the ground. Leaning over the jeep guard-rails, I peer hard at the red forest floor—nothing but mud. When squinting fails, I try quick-blinking to bring the patterns into existence. No dice.

"Lara and her cubs. They must have come here for a drink," concurs Swanand Deshpande, one of the natural-ists at Waghoba Eco Lodge, where I am spending the